

1.6 Distributions

This is where the beauty of open source lies. We found over 350 different distributions of Linux on www.linux.org! We can't say all of them are bug-free, but work is ongoing, and support is available for all major distributions. Just Google around for "Linux distributions," and you will find plenty of sites that offer downloads. Or just head to <http://www.linux.org/dist/> or www.distrowatch.com.

Linux is available for everything—from home PCs to embedded systems, enterprise applications and Web servers to handhelds. Many distributions are hosted at ftp sites and come in the .iso (image file) format—all you need to do is download the file and burn a CD from it. Boot with the CD, and you are on your way to Linux on your desktop. It can't get any simpler!

In Linux land, more is merrier. But what is easy to install and use for a first-timer?

Of course, it is impossible to review each distribution and judge which of them is the "easiest." However, we think we're secure betting our money on some of the well known distributions—Red Hat, SUSE, Mandrake, Fedora, Gentoo and Ubuntu. All these work well for home use, and can do almost anything you can do on a Windows machine. There are some things however, such as gaming and listening to MP3s, which cannot be readily achieved on Linux. But there are work-arounds for this and we talk about it in the later chapters.

The size and functionality of the different versions varies: the distros (as distributions are often called) can be from 100 MB to 4 to 5 GB. You even have tiny distros that can be booted off a floppy! It's obvious that you have a size vs. feature trade-off. Generally, when you start the install process, you will be given an option to choose the applications you want. All the bigger distributions we've mentioned invariably have a reasonably good office suite, image editors, multimedia players, browsers (it is now mostly Mozilla Firefox, which, by the way, is an open source